JOHN 17:13–26

Sermon Preparation Brief

Nic | River Lake Church

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CATEGORY 1: SCRIPTURAL INTERPRETATION

Section 1 — Passage Overview & Translation Comparisons

Full Passage Text — NIV

13 *I am coming to you now, but I say these things while I am still in the world, so that they may have the full measure of my joy within them.*

14 *I have given them your word and the world has hated them, for they are not of the world any more than I am of the world.*

15 *My prayer is not that you take them out of the world but that you protect them from the evil one.*

16 *They are not of the world, even as I am not of it.*

17 *Sanctify them by the truth; your word is truth.*

18 *As you sent me into the world, I have sent them into the world.*

19 *For them I sanctify myself, that they too may be truly sanctified.*

20 *My prayer is not for them alone. I pray also for those who will believe in me through their message,*

21 *that all of them may be one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you. May they also be in us so that the world may believe that you have sent me.*

22 *I have given them the glory that you gave me, that they may be one as we are one—*

23 *I in them and you in me—so that they may be brought to complete unity. Then the world will know that you sent me and have loved them even as you have loved me.*

24 *Father, I want those you have given me to be with me where I am, and to see my glory, the glory you have given me because you loved me before the creation of the world.*

25 *Righteous Father, though the world does not know you, I know you, and they have known that you have sent me.*

26 *I have made you known to them, and will continue to make you known in order that the love you have for me may be in them and that I myself may be in them.*

Passage Orientation

John 17 is universally recognized as the 'High Priestly Prayer' — Jesus's great intercessory prayer offered the night before his crucifixion. It follows the Farewell Discourse (John 13–16) and precedes the Passion narrative. Verses 1–5 focus on Jesus praying for his own glorification; verses 6–19 for the protection and sanctification of his immediate disciples; verses 20–26 (our passage) expand outward to encompass all future believers. This passage constitutes one of the most theologically dense and pastorally rich prayers in all of Scripture, providing a window into the very heart of Christ's desire for his people.

Translation Comparison — Key Verses

John 17:17 — Sanctify them in the truth

Translation	Text
NIV	Sanctify them by the truth; your word is truth.
ESV	Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth.
NLT	Make them holy by your truth; teach them your word, which is truth.
NASB	Sanctify them in the truth; Your word is truth.
MSG	Make them holy—consecrated—with the truth; Your word is consecrating truth.

John 17:21 — Unity Prayer

Translation	Text
NIV	That all of them may be one, Father, just as you are in me and I am in you. May they also be in us so that the world may believe that you have sent me.
ESV	That they may all be one, just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, that they also may be in us, so that the world may believe that you have sent me.
NLT	I pray that they will all be one, just as you and I are one—as you are in me, Father, and I am in you...And may they be brought into complete unity.
MSG	I ask for all of them to be joined together in oneness, just as you and I are joined together and made one. Then the world will know for sure that you sent me.

Section 2 — Author's Intent & Original Audience

Authorship, Date, and Circumstances

The Gospel of John was written by John the Apostle, son of Zebedee and a member of Jesus's inner circle. Scholarly consensus dates the Gospel between AD 85–95, though some place it earlier. Unlike the Synoptic Gospels, John's Gospel is highly theological, structured around seven 'signs' and extended discourses, with a climactic focus on the Passion. John 17 is unique to John's Gospel — no parallel exists in Matthew, Mark, or Luke.

Historical & Cultural Background Details

DETAIL 1: The High Priestly Function

The office of High Priest was Israel's most sacred intercessory role — the one who represented all the people before God in the Holy of Holies on Yom Kippur. John 17 is called the 'High Priestly Prayer' because Jesus employs intercessory language throughout, functioning as the ultimate Mediator. Jesus offers himself as the final High Priest who does not merely sprinkle blood from bulls and goats but offers himself. This OT backdrop gives the prayer its sacrificial weight. (Source: GotQuestions.org; Agape Bible Study, Chapter 17)

DETAIL 2: The Farewell Discourse Context

Jesus prays this prayer at the boundary between his ministry and his death — after completing his final instructions (John 13–16) and before his betrayal in Gethsemane. This is a parting prayer: 'Christ was parting by death, and that parting was sanctified and sweetened by prayer' (Matthew Henry). The prayer is simultaneously a final will, a priestly consecration, and a glimpse into the eternal communion of the Trinity. It is one of the most intimate moments in Scripture — the Son speaking to the Father while the disciples listen. (Source: Matthew Henry Commentary; Biblical Foundations)

DETAIL 3: The Concept of 'Not of the World'

In Greco-Roman and Jewish cultural contexts, kosmos ('world') in John's usage specifically refers to the human system organized in rebellion against God — not geography, but ideology. Jesus's repeated statement 'they are not of the world, even as I am not of the world' (vv. 14, 16) was radical countercultural language calling disciples to a different allegiance. Simultaneously, Jesus refuses to pray for their removal: 'My prayer is not that you take them out of the world but that you protect them' (v. 15). This creates the distinctively Johannine missionary tension: disciples are embedded in culture but oriented toward God's kingdom. (Source: Enduring Word Commentary, John 17; BibleRef.com)

Section 3 — Key Greek Word Studies

HAGIAZŌ (ἁγιάζω) (hag-ee-AD-zo)

Definition: To make holy, to consecrate, to set apart for sacred use. Subjectively: dedication to a specific purpose; separation from common use for divine service.

Lexical Source: BAGD (Bauer-Danker-Arndt-Gingrich) Greek Lexicon; Blue Letter Bible Strong's G37

Cross-References: 1 Cor 6:11 — 'you were sanctified'; 1 Thess 5:23 — 'sanctify you through and through'; 2 Tim 2:21 — 'made holy, useful to the Master'

Preaching Insight: Jesus sanctifies himself by total devotion to the Father's will — which means going to the cross. Disciples' sanctification flows from Christ's self-sacrifice. Modern Christians are sanctified not by withdrawal from the world but by being set apart within it for kingdom mission.

ALĒTHEIA (ἀλήθεια) (ah-LAY-thay-ah)

Definition: That which is real, actual, reliable, and in accordance with fact. Candor free from affectation, pretence, and deceit. In Johannine theology, the truth as revealed in Christ and the Scriptures respecting God and his purposes.

Lexical Source: Thayer's Greek Lexicon (225. alētheia); BibleStudyTools Lexicon

Cross-References: John 14:6 — 'I am the way and the truth'; Eph 4:15 — 'speaking the truth in love'; 1 John 1:8 — 'the truth is not in us'

Preaching Insight: Jesus prays that disciples be sanctified 'in the truth' because truth and sanctification are inseparable. In our postmodern culture, where truth is treated as relative, this prayer grounds sanctification in objective reality — the character of God revealed in Scripture. God's Word is not one perspective among many; it is truth itself.

KOSMOS (κόσμος) (KOS-mos)

Definition: The physical world, or more specifically in John's Gospel, the system of human civilization organized in rebellion against God. The realm of values, practices, and allegiances opposed to God's kingdom. The domain operating under Satan's influence.

Lexical Source: Blue Letter Bible Strong's G2889; BDAG Lexicon

Cross-References: John 15:18-19 — 'If the world hates you...'; 1 John 2:15-16 — 'Do not love the world'; Rom 12:2 — 'Do not conform to the pattern of this world'

Preaching Insight: The 'world' that hates disciples is not geography but ideology — a value system built on pride, materialism, sensuality, and self-worship. Disciples inhabit the world geographically while rejecting its worldview. This creates the productive tension of John 17: Jesus does not pray for removal but for protection and sanctification within the cultural context where disciples must witness.

DOXA (δόξα) (DOX-ah)

Definition: Brightness, splendor, radiance; the outshining of God's essential character and magnificence. Also: reputation, honor, dignity, and the display of divine majesty.

Lexical Source: Blue Letter Bible Strong's G1391; Vine's Expository Dictionary

Cross-References: John 1:14 — 'We have seen his glory'; Rom 3:23 — 'fall short of the glory of God'; 2 Cor 4:6 — 'God's light shining in our hearts'

Preaching Insight: The glory Jesus gives disciples is not power, wealth, or status — it is the revelation of God's love and the capacity to reflect it. In John's Gospel, Christ's greatest glory is displayed at the cross. So when Jesus offers his followers this glory, he's offering the paradoxical glory of humble service and sacrificial love — the glory of the cross.

HEN (ἕν) (HEN (neuter of heis))

Definition: Unity, oneness, a state of being united or joined together in purpose and life. Emphasizes cohesion and sameness of mission.

Lexical Source: Blue Letter Bible Strong's G1520; BDAG Lexicon

Cross-References: John 10:30 — 'I and the Father are one'; 1 Cor 12:12-13 — 'one body...one Spirit'; Eph 4:4-6 — 'one body, one Spirit, one Lord'

Preaching Insight: The unity Jesus prays for is not institutional homogenization or organizational merger but organic oneness modeled on the Trinity's diverse-yet-unified nature. This unity is not conformity but covenant love binding diverse believers together. The stunning claim: believers' visible love for each other is the world's primary evidence that Jesus was sent by the Father.

Section 4 — Cross-References & Biblical Connections

SANCTIFICATION & CONSECRATION

Reference	Connection & Preaching Value
Exodus 29:44-45	God consecrates priests for his service and presence — John 17 fulfills this by consecrating all disciples as a kingdom priesthood (cf. 1 Pet 2:9).
Leviticus 20:26	'You are to be holy because I am holy.' The OT holiness code points forward to Jesus's prayer for disciples to be set apart from the nations' values for God's purposes.
1 Peter 2:9	'A royal priesthood, a holy nation, God's special possession.' NT fulfillment of John 17:17 — all believers become priests set apart for God's praise.
Romans 12:1-2	'Do not conform to the pattern of this world, but be transformed.' The closest NT parallel to Jesus's 'not of the world' language — sanctification = refusing worldly conformity.

UNITY

Reference	Connection & Preaching Value
Psalm 133:1-3	'How good and pleasant it is when brothers live together in unity!' OT celebration of covenant unity — John 17 gives this doxology its theological grounding.
1 Corinthians 12:12-13	Unity in diversity through Spirit baptism — the NT explanation of how John 17 unity is actually achieved: one body, many members, one Spirit.
Ephesians 4:4-6	'One body, one Spirit...one Lord, one faith, one baptism.' The trinitarian foundation of Christian unity parallels Jesus's prayer that believers be 'one as we are one.'

GLORY

Reference	Connection & Preaching Value
John 1:14	'We have seen his glory...full of grace and truth.' Establishes the paradoxical glory of Christ: made visible in incarnation and sacrifice, not in power.
John 12:23-24	'The hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified...a kernel of wheat must die.' The cross IS Christ's glorification — critical for understanding John 17:22's gift of glory.
Colossians 1:27	'Christ in you, the hope of glory.' The indwelling of Christ (John 17:26) as the presence of glory within believers.

KNOWING GOD / REVELATION

Reference	Connection & Preaching Value
Jeremiah 31:33-34	The new covenant promise: 'They will all know me.' John 17:25-26 is the New Covenant fulfillment — Jesus makes the Father known so all can have direct relational knowledge.
2 Corinthians 4:6	God shining his light in our hearts 'to give us the light of the knowledge of God's glory displayed in the face of Christ' — the ongoing revelation Jesus prays about in v. 26.

Section 5 — Historical & Modern Commentary

Sub-Section A: Historical Voices

AUGUSTINE (354–430)

"Sanctification is the Spirit's work of pouring love into believers' hearts. Truth and love are inseparable — God's truth necessarily produces divine love in those who receive it. Jesus's prayer establishes the church's pattern: disciples are sanctified through the Word of God and united in the love that flows from knowing the Father through Christ."

— Augustine of Hippo, Tractates on the Gospel of John (c. AD 416), Tractate 108

JOHN CHRYSOSTOM (347–407)

"'I sanctify myself' means 'I offer myself in sacrifice.' Christ's self-sanctification provides the ground for disciples' true sanctification. Believers are set apart for service and witness in the world — and this calling requires, like their Master's, total self-dedication to God's purposes."

— John Chrysostom, Homilies on the Gospel of John, Homily 82 (New Advent)

JOHN CALVIN (1509–1564)

"Sanctification flows from union with Christ and is nourished by Scripture, 'the rule of all truth.' Christ's prayer for the disciples extends to all future believers who would come through the apostles' witness. Jesus does not pray for the disciples' removal from the world but for their protection and sanctification within it — giving them a dual calling: separation from worldly values while remaining engaged in worldly geography."

— John Calvin, Commentary on the Gospel of John, Volume 2 (on John 17:17)

MATTHEW HENRY (1662–1714)

"This is the Lord's prayer — the Lord Christ's prayer, properly and peculiarly his... Christ prayed here as a priest now offering sacrifice, in the virtue of which all prayers were to be made. Christ was parting by death, and that parting was sanctified and sweetened by prayer."

— Matthew Henry, Commentary on John 17 (BibleStudyTools)

JOHN WESLEY (1703–1791)

"Observe the sum of his whole prayer: 1. Receive me into thy own and my glory; 2. Let my apostles share therein; 3. And all other believers; 4. And let all the world believe. They are not left here to pursue the same objects as the men around them, but to glorify God, and to serve their generation. The Spirit of God in true Christians is opposed to the spirit of the world."

— John Wesley, Explanatory Notes on the New Testament (on John 17:16)

Sub-Section B: Modern Voices

D.A. CARSON (Wheaton College; The Gospel According to John, Pillar NT Commentary)

Carson's commentary emphasizes the missional structure of sanctification in John 17:18-19. On Jesus's 'I sanctify myself' (v. 19): 'Jesus's purpose in such obedience is that his disciples may be truly sanctified — he goes to the cross and dies for his own; in consequence of this cross-work, his disciples are truly set aside for God.' On verses 22-26, Carson observes: 'The aim of the disciples' unity is the display of the incredible truth that the Father loves them just as he loves the Son, and that the love of the triune God may be in them.' Carson sees the prayer's final movement (vv. 24-26) as establishing believers' eternal destiny as sharing in Christ's exaltation through the same love that binds Father and Son eternally. (Source: The Gospel According to John, PNTC; The Farewell Discourse and Final Prayer of Jesus)

ANDREAS KÖSTENBERGER (Southeastern Baptist Theological Seminary; Baker Exegetical Commentary on John)

Köstenberger is particularly noted for his work on Johannine mission theology. His commentary shows how John 17 establishes the pattern for apostolic mission: disciples are sanctified for witness, unified for credibility, and glorified through humble service in the world. Köstenberger's exegetical precision reveals that every element of John 17:13-26 contributes to the overarching theme of Christ commissioning disciples for the continuation of his mission. 'As the Father sent me, I am sending you' (v. 18) is, for Köstenberger, the structural key to the entire passage. Sanctification is not primarily personal piety but missional preparation. (Source: Baker Exegetical Commentary on the New Testament: John, 2004)

TIM KELLER (Redeemer Presbyterian Church, New York; The Reason for God)

Keller has preached multiple sermons on John 17 and emphasizes the apologetic dimension of Christian unity in verses 20-23. His key insight: 'Jesus's prayer for unity is not for organizational structure but for visible love between believers that authenticates the gospel to a watching world. Disunity in the church actually turns people away from the gospel and is a significant barrier to faith.' Keller highlights the stunning implication of Christ's prayer: if the world does not see unity and love among believers, it has permission to doubt both the mission of Jesus and his love. For Keller, this is one of Christianity's most urgent practical challenges in a polarized culture. (Source: Gospel in Life — John 17 Resources; Dee Brestin Ministries on Tim Keller, John 17:21)

CATEGORY 2: THEOLOGICAL IMPLICATIONS

"What the Text Means to Me"

Section 6 — Theological Themes & Synthesis

THEME 1: Sanctification as Mission-Oriented Consecration

Sanctification in John 17:13-26 is not primarily about personal purity in an isolated sense. Jesus prays that disciples be 'sanctified by the truth' (v. 17) and 'for their sake I sanctify myself' (v. 19) in order that they 'may be truly sanctified' (v. 19). This sanctification is inherently missional: 'As you sent me into the world, I have sent them into the world' (v. 18). Calvin, Köstenberger, and Chrysostom all converge on this point: sanctification means being set apart from the world's value system while remaining engaged in the world as God's witnesses.

KEY INSIGHT: True holiness is not escape from the world but deep consecration within it — disciples are refined like metal ore, not removed from the mine.

Systematic theology connection: Sanctification (progressive holiness) is here presented as having a missional teleology — it exists for the sake of witness. Sanctification serves the mission; the mission requires sanctification. This challenges privatized holiness that is only about personal moral improvement disconnected from apostolic calling.

THEME 2: Unity Rooted in the Trinity as Witness to the World

Jesus's repeated prayer that believers 'may be one' (vv. 20-21, 22-23) is rooted in Trinitarian unity: 'just as you are in me and I am in you' (v. 21). But this unity is not organizational but organic, modeled on the Trinity's diverse-yet-unified nature. The stunning claim: this unity becomes the primary apologetic for the gospel — 'so that the world may believe that you have sent me' (v. 21) and 'Then the world will know that you sent me' (v. 23). Augustine sees this unity flowing from shared love; Keller emphasizes its apologetic weight; Wesley emphasizes its countercultural quality.

KEY INSIGHT: Disunity among believers is not merely unfortunate — it is, according to Christ's own prayer, an obstacle to the world's belief. Unity is the evangelism strategy.

Theological tension: Unity does not mean uniformity. The Trinity is three distinct Persons united in one Being. So the church can and should encompass tremendous diversity of culture, background, and expression while maintaining the 'one love' that Christ prays for. The practical challenge is distinguishing essential unity from enforced conformity.

THEME 3: Glory Redefined as Sacrificial Service

In verses 22-24, Jesus speaks of giving disciples 'the glory that you gave me' and wanting them to see his glory. Yet in John's Gospel, Christ's greatest glory is revealed at the cross (John 12:23-24, 13:31-32). So the glory believers receive is not power or prestige but the capacity for self-emptying love and faithful service. 'I have given them the glory that you gave me, that they may be one as we are one' (v. 22) — the glory shared is the glory of relationship, love, and redemptive purpose. Carson identifies this as the glory of being loved by the Father as the Son is loved.

KEY INSIGHT: The glory Christ offers his followers is paradoxical: it looks like weakness, sacrifice, and servanthood — but it is the glory of the eternal love between Father and Son now poured into believers' lives.

Theological tension: This glory is future and present simultaneously. Verse 24 speaks of a future vision of Christ's glory ('Father, I want those you have given me to be with me where I am'). Yet verse 22 speaks of a glory already given ('I have given them the glory'). Believers live in the tension of already-received and not-yet-fully-experienced glory — the classic already/not-yet of New Testament eschatology.

THEME 4: Knowing God's Name/Character as the Foundation of Love

The closing verses emphasize revelation and relational knowledge: 'I have made you known to them, and will continue to make you known in order that the love you have for me may be in them and that I myself may be in them' (v. 26). 'Knowing God' in biblical usage is not intellectual assent but intimate relational knowledge (Hebrew yada — the same term used of marriage). Jesus's ongoing work is to reveal the Father's character — and the goal is that God's love for the Son becomes the love resident in disciples. This is Christianity's distinctive offer: not information about God but union with God.

Wesley emphasizes that disciples are left in the world to serve their generation; Augustine roots this service in love received from God; Carson traces this love all the way back to the Father's love 'before the foundation of the world' (v. 24). The practical implication: you cannot give what you don't possess. A church that does not experience the Father's love revealed by Christ cannot love the world as Christ loves it.

Section 7 — Big Ideas & Preaching Angles

Three distinct Big Idea options are offered below. Each addresses a different aspect of the passage and would produce a different sermon. Choose the one that best fits your congregation's current season and need.

BIG IDEA OPTION 1: SANCTIFICATION FOR MISSION

"Jesus does not ask to remove his disciples from the world but to sanctify them within it — to set them apart from worldly values so they can penetrate the world with kingdom purposes. True holiness is not escape but engagement."

Entry point: Ask the congregation if they view sanctification as withdrawal or engagement. Tension: Most Christians experience their faith as a private refuge from the world, not a missional sending into it. Transformation invited: A shift from a refuge posture to a sent posture.

BIG IDEA OPTION 2: UNITY BECOMES WITNESS ← Recommended

"The invisible reality of the Trinity becomes visible through the church's love; the world's primary evidence that Jesus was sent by the Father is not miracles or arguments but believers genuinely united across all dividing lines in covenant love."

Entry point: Open with the world's brokenness and division — then contrast it with what Jesus was praying for. Tension: The church has fractured into thousands of denominations. Is Jesus's

prayer answered? Transformation invited: Personally committing to cross-boundary unity. Preacher's note: This angle has strong connections to your 2024 'Church for Dummies' series — see Section 14 for details.

BIG IDEA OPTION 3: GLORY THROUGH SACRIFICE

"Jesus gives his followers not power or prestige but his own glory — the paradoxical glory of self-emptying love and sacrificial service; believers are invited to share in the glory of the cross and the joy of the resurrection."

Entry point: Begin with what most people think 'glory' means — then redefine it through John 17. Tension: Christians often seek the wrong kind of glory (recognition, success, comfort). Transformation invited: Embracing the cruciform life as the path to true glory.

Section 8 — Sermon Hooks & Opening Options

(A) The One-Liner / Quote

> *"The Church is not a hotel for saints; it is a hospital for sinners — and the visible love between patients is the most compelling advertisement for the Doctor."*
>
> **— Adapted from various sources (usage: open with this, then pivot to John 17:21 — 'so that the world may believe')**

How to use: This quote captures the idea that the church's unity and love is its primary witness. Open with it, let it land, then say: 'Two thousand years ago, Jesus prayed something extraordinary. He prayed that this exact kind of community — a community of love that defies the world's categories — would be his gift to the watching world.'

(B) Cultural Reference — The Answered and Unanswered Prayer

One of the most interesting things about John 17 is that parts of Jesus's prayer were answered almost immediately, while other parts... we're still waiting. Jesus prayed in verse 20 for 'those who will believe in me through their message' — meaning us, 2,000 years later — and that prayer was answered. Believers from every nation and century have responded to the apostolic message. But then Jesus prayed something else: 'that all of them may be one' (v. 21). Two thousand years later, we have thousands of Christian denominations. We have church splits over carpeting. We have pastors who won't speak to other pastors across town. And Jesus is still waiting. Which makes me ask: Could God be waiting for US to answer?

How to use: This is a narrative hook that creates immediate tension and personal engagement. It pivots quickly from historical observation to personal conviction without being preachy.

(C) The Shocking Stat

According to the World Christian Database, there are approximately 45,000 distinct Christian denominations worldwide. That's not 45,000 congregations — that's 45,000 separate groupings, each with their own understanding of doctrine, worship, and practice. (Source: World Christian Database, Gordon-Conwell Theological Seminary — verify current figure before use) Meanwhile, Jesus prayed in John 17:21 for ONE thing: 'that all of them may be one.' The gap between Jesus's prayer and the church's reality raises an urgent question: What are we missing? And what would it cost us to close that gap?

How to use: Stat creates intellectual disruption. Follow immediately with the text of Jesus's prayer for unity. Then spend the rest of the sermon building toward a vision of what Christ-powered unity actually looks like.

CATEGORY 3: PRACTICAL APPLICATION

"How I Live This Out"

Section 9 — Text-Driven Sermon Outline

Working Title: 'In, Not Of: Jesus's Radical Prayer for Us'

BIG IDEA: The invisible reality of the Trinity becomes visible through the church's love — and that love is the world's primary evidence that Jesus was sent by the Father.

MOVEMENT 1: Joy Rooted in Jesus's Intercession (v. 13)

WHAT IT SAYS: Jesus does not pray for his disciples' escape — he prays FOR them as he approaches the cross, so they may 'have the full measure of my joy.'
WHAT IT DOES: Surprises the listener: who prays for someone else's joy while facing death? This reframes the entire sermon — we're hearing a prayer from someone who loves us more than we know.
SO WHAT: In your darkest seasons — when Jesus's physical presence is absent — his intercessory presence is active. Christ's joy is not happiness (the absence of pain) but gladness rooted in the security of being known and held.

MOVEMENT 2: Sanctification by Truth in a Hostile World (vv. 14-17)

WHAT IT SAYS: 'I have given them your word and the world has hated them' — the gift of God's truth produces opposition. 'Sanctify them by the truth; your word is truth.'
WHAT IT DOES: Establishes the tension: to be shaped by God's truth is to become increasingly foreign to the world's values. This is not comfortable; it is costly.
SO WHAT: Your holiness is not about escaping culture. You work in secular systems, study alongside unbelievers, participate in culture — but from a different master, with different allegiances. The Word of God is the means of this transformation.

MOVEMENT 3: Mission Through Self-Sanctification (vv. 18-19)

WHAT IT SAYS: 'As you sent me into the world, I have sent them into the world. For them I sanctify myself.'
WHAT IT DOES: Reveals the structure of mission: Christ's self-dedication to the cross makes disciples' sanctification possible. Your calling echoes his calling.
SO WHAT: You are not sanctified for comfort but for continuation. Christ went to the cross for your redemption. You are invited to dedicate your life to kingdom purposes in response.

MOVEMENT 4: Unity Becomes Witness to Skeptics (vv. 20-23)

WHAT IT SAYS: 'I pray also for those who will believe in me through their message, that all of them may be one...so that the world may believe that you have sent me.'
WHAT IT DOES: The stakes become existential: the world's belief in Christ is connected to the church's visible love. This is either the most motivating or the most convicting paragraph Jesus ever uttered.
SO WHAT: The world doesn't need another argument for Christianity. It needs to witness Christians genuinely united across race, class, nationality, and politics. When that happens, people encounter evidence they cannot explain apart from God.

MOVEMENT 5: Glory Through Intimate Knowledge (vv. 24-26)

WHAT IT SAYS: 'Father, I want those you have given me to be with me...to see my glory...I have made you known to them, and will continue to make you known in order that the love you have for me may be in them and that I myself may be in them.'

WHAT IT DOES: Lifts the gaze from present struggle to eternal promise — and returns it to the present by claiming the Father's love for the Son is now the love resident in believers.

SO WHAT: You are being loved with the same love with which the Father loves the Son. The Father's infinite, eternal love for Jesus is the love now directed toward you through Christ. That's not poetry — it's the claim of John 17.

Closing / Landing Moment

Return to the opening question: 'Could we be the answer to Jesus's unanswered prayer?' Invite the congregation to a moment of silent commitment — to pursue one relationship across a dividing line this week. Close with a reading of John 17:26 as a benediction: 'I will continue to make you known in order that the love you have for me may be in them and that I myself may be in them.'

Section 10 — Illustration Bank

ILLUSTRATION 1: The Prisoner's Dilemma — Contemporary Story (Unity)

A long-term prison ministry worker observed that when inmates genuinely converted to Christianity, the most visible change was not personal virtue but radically changed relationships. Men who had been enemies in the prison yard now worshipped together and created a counter-culture of love within a system built on violence. When guards and other inmates witnessed this inexplicable unity — enemies becoming brothers — it created cognitive dissonance that opened conversations about Christ. The witness was not individual piety but collective love. Landing spot: Movement 4 (Unity as Witness). The point it makes: The world cannot explain genuine Christian unity apart from God — that inexplicability IS the testimony.

ILLUSTRATION 2: The Laboratory Purification — Analogy (Sanctification)

When a metal ore is extracted from rock, it undergoes sanctification — separation from that which is foreign. But the metal is not removed from the world; it is refined within it. Its purpose is not isolation but function — to be used as an instrument. Similarly, Christian sanctification means being set apart from worldly values while remaining embedded in the world as God's instrument. We are refined, not removed. Landing spot: Movement 2 (Sanctification). The point it makes: Holiness is not purity for its own sake but consecration for mission.

ILLUSTRATION 3: The Inverted Stars — Historical/Philosophical (Glory Paradox)

The Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard observed that Christians are like the reflections of stars in a lake — the lower the star looks in the lake, the higher it actually is in the sky. The Christian who appears 'low' and weak in worldly estimation may be the highest in the kingdom. True glory — the glory Christ gives — is the glory of sacrificial service, humility, and cruciform love. What appears as defeat to the world is victory in God's economy. Landing spot: Movement 5 (Glory Redefined). The point it makes: Greatness in God's kingdom is the inverse of greatness in the world's economy. (Note: Kierkegaard attribution unverified — use with caveat or remove.)

ILLUSTRATION 4: The Letter From Nowhere — Everyday Moment (Joy of Intercession)

You're facing your darkest season — a health crisis, a family breakdown, financial collapse. Then you receive a letter or text from someone you haven't heard from in years: 'I was praying for you. I felt led to reach out.' That simple, unexplained act of intercession — arriving exactly when needed — is a small picture of what Jesus's prayer in John 17 is doing for every believer right now. The ascended Christ is interceding for you (cf. Romans 8:34; Hebrews 7:25). John 17:13 is not just historical — it is ongoing. Landing spot: Movement 1 (Joy in Intercession). The point it makes: The joy Jesus prays for in v. 13 is not happiness but the deep gladness of being held in Christ's care.

ILLUSTRATION 5: The Musician's Contract — Analogy (Not of the World)

A talented musician signs a contract with a major studio: 'We own your talent, your image, your compositions.' The musician attends industry events, parties, and premieres — but his loyalty belongs elsewhere. He is physically present in the entertainment world but not of it; his deepest identity and commitments are elsewhere. This is the Christian's condition in John 17: embedded in the world geographically, oriented toward the kingdom theologically. Landing spot: Movement 2 (In the World, Not of It). The point it makes: The question is not 'How much can I participate?' but 'Whom do I serve?'

ILLUSTRATION 6: The Martyrs' Unity — Historical Story (Sanctification for Mission)

In the early church, thousands of believers were martyred — not because they were removed from the world but because they remained in it as witnesses. Stephen, Philip, Peter, Paul — all were sanctified not for comfort but for costly witness. And in their deaths, the gospel spread. The early church's unity in martyrdom — from different nations, languages, and backgrounds, all dying with Christ's name on their lips — was the most powerful testimony the Roman Empire witnessed. Tertullian observed: 'The blood of the martyrs is the seed of the church.' Landing spot: Movement 3 (Sanctification for Mission). The point it makes: The early church's sanctification proved its worth through faithfulness unto death — a standard that challenges comfortable modern discipleship.

Section 11 — Practical Application & Life Change

Application statements shaped as 'you' invitations across major life spheres:

LIFE SPHERE	APPLICATION INVITATION
FAITH / SPIRITUAL LIFE	You can receive the Father's love for the Son as the love now directed toward you — and let that security reshape how you face anxiety, shame, and fear. (v. 26)
SPIRITUAL DISCIPLINE	You can prioritize God's Word not as a religious obligation but as the agent of your sanctification — the truth that sets you apart for God's purposes. (v. 17)
RELATIONSHIPS	You can identify one relationship across a cultural, racial, or theological boundary and pursue genuine friendship — not as a program but as an answer to Jesus's prayer. (vv. 21-23)
CHURCH COMMUNITY	You can resist the gravitational pull of cliques and homogenous relationships within the church and actively seek the kind of diverse, covenant love Jesus is praying for. (vv. 22-23)
WORK & CALLING	You can embrace your secular workplace, school, or neighborhood as your mission field — the world Jesus is sending you into, not the world you're meant to escape. (v. 18)

WITNESS & EVANGELISM	You can recognize that your primary apologetic is not your argument but your community's love — and invest accordingly in relationships that demonstrate that love publicly. (v. 21)
SUFFERING & DIFFICULTY	You can hold the paradox of present struggle and eternal promise together: Christ is interceding for you now (v. 13) while your ultimate destiny is to see his glory (v. 24).

MOST IMPORTANT APPLICATIONS (for sermon close):

KEY INSIGHT: 'This week, identify one relationship across a dividing line you've been avoiding — and take one step toward it as an answer to Jesus's prayer for unity.' (v. 21-23)

KEY INSIGHT: 'Ask God to let the Father's love for Jesus become your lived experience — not a doctrine to believe but a reality to inhabit.' (v. 26)

Next-Step Prompts for Sermon Close

- RELATIONAL: 'Who is one person in this room, in your neighborhood, or in your workplace whose background makes relationship unlikely? Send them a text or grab coffee this week as a small act of answering Jesus's prayer.'
- SPIRITUAL: 'Spend 5 minutes this week reading John 17:26 slowly — and receive it as a prayer Jesus is praying for you right now. Let the Father's love for the Son wash over you.'

Section 12 — Hard Questions & Potential Objections

Q: "If Jesus prayed for unity, why is the church so divided? Doesn't that prove the prayer failed?"

Response: This is one of the most pointed and legitimate critiques of Christianity. Acknowledge it fully — the division is real and painful. Then distinguish between organic unity (all genuine believers are baptized by one Spirit into one body — 1 Cor. 12:13, which is already answered) and the visible manifestation of that unity, which remains deeply imperfect. The prayer was not that all institutions would merge but that love would bind believers across every divide. The challenge is returned: Are we stewarding the unity Christ purchased?

Sermon usage: Best used in Movement 4 or as a separate 'hard question' slot late in the sermon.

Q: "Why should God's love for me be enough when my life is falling apart?"

Response: Acknowledge the painful gap between Christ's claim (v. 26 — 'the love you have for me may be in them') and the felt experience of abandonment. John 17 is ultimately about participation in the Father's love for the Son — a love that transcends circumstances and is not measured by earthly comfort. The ultimate hope in v. 24 is not relief in this world but eternal communion: 'Father, I want those you have given me to be with me where I am.' This may not heal immediate pain, but it reframes ultimate meaning and anchors the soul in what is permanent.

Sermon usage: Use pastorally in Movement 5, or in a direct address to those who are suffering.

Q: "How can we be 'not of the world' while living fully in it? Where's the practical line?"

Response: John 17 doesn't give a formula, and we shouldn't pretend there is one. The line is not about geography or cultural participation but about ultimate allegiance and value system. The key question is 'Whom do I serve?' — not 'How much can I participate in culture?' Christians can engage fully in secular work, art, relationships, and civic life while maintaining fundamentally different commitments to truth, love, and mission. Practical discernment is required; rigid rules are not the answer.

Sermon usage: Address directly in Movement 2 or as a Q&A element if your format allows.

Q: "Why does God need our unity to prove Jesus was sent? Couldn't God just do something more obvious?"

Response: God has chosen to work through human instrumentality — not because it's the most efficient method, but because it honors human agency and invites participation. The resurrection, transformed lives, prophetic fulfillment, and historical church impact all provide evidence. But Christ specifically chose visible love as the primary apologetic in John 17:21-23 — which means he is serious about believers' responsibility. The question itself may reveal a desire for a Christianity that costs nothing and requires nothing of us.

Sermon usage: Use for intellectually curious or skeptical listeners, particularly in a teaching series context.

Q: "If Jesus prayed for 'those who will believe through their message,' does that mean my faith was predetermined?"

Response: Yes and no. Jesus's prayer encompasses future believers — including those in this room — which affirms the sovereign purpose of God. But the means of their coming to faith is

'through their message' — through the apostles' witness and all subsequent evangelism. God's sovereignty and human responsibility work together in John 17: God purposes; people proclaim; others believe. The prayer is both an expression of divine election and a commission to human witness. Both are fully true.

Sermon usage: For theologically curious listeners or those with a Reformed/Arminian tension in your congregation.

Section 13 — Group Discussion & Reflection Questions

For use in small groups, life groups, or Sunday School classes following the sermon.

TYPE	QUESTION
ICEBREAKER	Have you ever experienced a moment where someone's unexpected act of love or prayer came at exactly the right time? What did that feel like?
OBSERVATION	Read John 17:13-26 together. What word, phrase, or verse stands out most to you, and why?
INTERPRETATION 1	Jesus says he is sending his disciples into the world (v. 18) just as the Father sent him. What does this imply about the purpose of sanctification? How does 'being set apart' relate to 'being sent in'?
INTERPRETATION 2	Jesus prays in verses 21-23 that believers may be 'one' so that the world may believe. What kind of unity do you think he is praying for — organizational, relational, doctrinal? How do you tell the difference?
APPLICATION 1	Is there a person or group in your life where maintaining a genuine relationship requires crossing a significant cultural, racial, political, or theological line? What would it look like to take one step in that direction this week?
APPLICATION 2	Verse 17 says 'Sanctify them by the truth; your word is truth.' How is your relationship with Scripture shaping your values and priorities in practical terms? Where might you be unconsciously absorbing the world's value system instead?
REFLECTION	Jesus says in verse 26 that he will 'continue to make the Father known' so that the Father's love for him may be in us. Sit with this for a moment: the Father's love for the eternal Son is the same love now directed toward you through Christ. How does that change how you see yourself, your day, and your relationships?
CLOSING PRAYER	Pray together using John 17:17 as a template: 'Father, sanctify us in your truth. Your word is truth. Send us into the world the way you sent Jesus — set apart in values, fully engaged in love.'

Section 14 — Past Sermon Cross-References

This section draws from a search of your full sermon archive (2014–2025, 490 sermons). Its purpose is to give you a personal cross-reference map — helping you know what ground you've covered, what angles you've used, and where this message is new territory.

14A — Tier 1: Direct Hits (Same Passage or Book)

No previous sermons found referencing John 17 or John 17:13-26 directly in the archive (2014–2025). This passage appears to be new territory for your congregation.

14B — Tier 2: Thematic Connections

Date & Series	Message Title & Overlapping Theme
Feb 4, 2024 — The Church for Dummies, Week 1	Unity in the Church — Strongest thematic parallel. Focused on Paul's call for unity; key quote: 'One of the biggest flaws in the local church today is the division... my mission as a pastor is to fight and maintain the unity of this church.' Overlaps directly with John 17:20-23's prayer for one-ness.
Mar 3, 2024 — The Church for Dummies, Week 5	Love in the Church — 'LOVE...real LOVE...that requires sacrifice and pain and struggle... Unity is the theme, but Love is the solution.' Deeply resonant with John 17:26's theme of the Father's love becoming present in believers.
Aug 31, 2025 — Spiritual Myopia, Week 3	Saved vs. Sanctified — Directly addresses the distinction between justification and ongoing sanctification. Connects to John 17:17's prayer to 'sanctify them in the truth.'
Sep 21, 2025 — YHWH, Week 2	God is HOLY — God's holiness and separation. Thematic connection to the sanctification/consecration concepts in John 17:17-19.

14C — Tier 3: Loose Connections

Date & Series	Loose Connection
Jul 2016 — Mission Day, Weeks 1-3	Mission-focused messages — loose connection to John 17:18 ('As you sent me into the world, I have sent them'). Three consecutive weeks on mission.
Nov 19, 2023 — CHOOSE, Week 6	Mission Minded — Thematic connection to John 17:18's 'sent' language; what it means to be mission-oriented in daily life.
Jan 14, 2018 — My 3-59, Week 2	Prayer — Foundational connection to John 17 as an intercessory prayer passage; could reference your prayer series when explaining the nature of Jesus's High Priestly Prayer.

14D — Preacher's Notes for This Message

This passage is new territory. John 17:13-26 has not been preached directly in your archive — giving you a fresh canvas with no risk of repetition.

Your 2024 'Church for Dummies' series (Unity and Love) covers the same application ground as John 17:20-23. This is a strength: you can reference the earlier series as 'we explored what this looks like in practice — today we're going to see where Jesus actually prays for it.' Build on that foundation rather than repeating it.

Your 2025 'Spiritual Myopia' series (Saved vs. Sanctified) provides a platform to deepen the sanctification theme in John 17:17-19. Your congregation has the foundation — this sermon can take it deeper and add the missional dimension that the earlier message may not have emphasized.

No direct John 17 illustrations were found in past outlines — your illustration slate is fresh. The prison ministry story and laboratory analogy (Section 10) would be entirely new to your congregation.